

Korea Daily Brief

Friday, September 25, 2026

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RE: DPRK threatens ROK as 'collective punishment' target · Russia formally invites Kim · NK POW disclosure row
· DMZ mine probe · Lee-Sheinbaum summit

KOSPI
7,080.92
▲ +1.0%

USD/KRW
1,354.28
▼ -0.6%

BRENT
\$99.00
▼ -7.1%

BOK RATE
2.50%
Sep 2026

• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 North Korea threatened South Korea with 'collective punishment' if Seoul becomes a hub for US collective defense, while simultaneously Russia formally invited Kim Jong Un for a state visit per TASS.
- 2 President Lee Jae-myung publicly accused Zelensky of violating a non-disclosure agreement by announcing the transfer of two North Korean POWs to South Korea, sparking a ruling-opposition political brawl at home.
- 3 JCS Chairman Gen. Jin Yong-seop visited the 25th Division on Chuseok to check DMZ landmine probe preparations, as the Blue House confirmed it cannot rule out North Korean mine emplacement.

• TOP STORIES

DPRK

North Korea threatens South Korea with 'collective punishment' over US defence hub role; rejects nuclear test halt call

A North Korean official declared South Korea would become a target of 'collective punishment' if Seoul transforms into a hub for US collective defense, per a Yonhap/Reuters report citing KCNA. Separately, KCNA rejected international calls to halt nuclear tests, reiterating that the DPRK's nuclear weapons status is 'irreversible.' The statements follow FM **Choe Son Hui**'s nuclear irreversibility declaration at UNGA on September 24 and Kim Jong Un's September 22 'new-type weapon' test, continuing a pattern of paired kinetic and diplomatic escalation.

Yonhap / Reuters, Sep 25

US-KOREA

President Lee accuses Zelensky of violating non-disclosure agreement by publicly announcing North Korean POW transfer to South Korea

Lee Jae-myung posted on X that Ukraine's president violated a confidentiality agreement when he publicly announced at UNGA on September 23 that two North Korean prisoners of war had been transferred to South Korea. A Blue House official clarified Seoul had received vague prior diplomatic notice but that the exact form of disclosure was not specified; the official stated the government had consistently sought to handle the matter quietly for safety and humanitarian reasons. The ruling Democratic Party called it a breach of bilateral trust, while the opposition People Power Party accused the government of being 'only mindful of Kim Jong-un' for keeping the transfer secret from the public.

NK News / 뉴시스, Sep 25

US-KOREA

JCS chief visits 25th Division on Chuseok to inspect DMZ landmine blast probe; DPRK mine emplacement not ruled out

JCS Chairman Gen. **Jin Yong-seop** traveled to the 25th Division on Chuseok to review the Joint Field Investigation Task Force's preparedness for an on-site probe into the September 21 DMZ blast that injured three soldiers including a battalion commander. The JCS rebutted claims that injured personnel were evacuated by US military helicopters, stating ROK Army Medevac helicopters (KUH-1M) performed the airlift. The Blue House confirmed that North Korean mine emplacement remains one of the hypotheses under investigation, alongside the possibility of legacy mines from the area where North Korea conducted a box mine provocation in 2015.

Yonhap / 뉴시스 / 경향신문, Sep 25

• OVERNIGHT

NK-RUSSIA-CHINA	Vietnam and North Korea pledge closer defence ties during Hanoi talks · Reuters Vice Defence Minister Ryo Chol-ung's Hanoi visit yields defence cooperation pledge.
DPRK	North Korean cybercriminals suspected behind \$352M Bitget crypto exchange heist · NK Pro / CNBC Largest virtual theft of 2026; CEO suspects DPRK; hot wallets hit Sep 25.
DPRK	Satellite imagery shows North Korea building new warships simultaneously at Nampho and Chongjin shipyards · NK Pro Dual-coast naval construction since July — east and west coast yards active concurrently.
US-KOREA	South Korea and Mexico adopt 2026–2030 joint action plan covering defense, crude oil, and AI · Yonhap English Korea-Mexico FTA still blocked by USMCA origin-rule complications.
CHINA-KOREA	Xi says US and China reached new trade arrangement at White House summit with Trump · Yonhap English Trade ceasefire extended to Jan 10, 2027; AI guardrails dispute unresolved.
US-KOREA	Russian deputy FM warns Korea: military support for Ukraine will negatively affect Seoul-Moscow ties · 한겨레

• STAT OF THE DAY

\$352M

Crypto stolen from Bitget, attributed to North Korean hackers

Crypto platform Bitget's CEO suspects North Korea is responsible for the \$351.6M theft from its hot wallets, making it the largest virtual heist of 2026 so far.

CNBC / NK Pro

PYONGYANG WATCH · KCNA

KIM JONG UN **WATCH FLAG**

● No appearance (3d since last)

TOP KCNA ARTICLES

1. North Korea says South Korea a target if it becomes US collective defence hub

KCNA declared ROK would face 'collective punishment' if it becomes a US collective defense hub, directly responding to ROK Defense Minister statements. — KCNA (Reuters)

2. North Korea rejects call to halt nuclear tests

KCNA rejected international calls to halt nuclear testing, reiterating nuclear weapons status is 'irreversible.' — KCNA (Reuters)

3. North Korea says 240mm rocket's range upgraded to instill fear in South Koreans

KCNA confirmed the 240mm multiple-launch rocket system was upgraded for extended range and explicitly framed the upgrade as intended to 'instill fear' in South Korea. — KCNA (NK News)

SENIOR OFFICIALS

Choe Son Hui · Foreign Minister, DPRK

Delivered DPRK's blanket nuclear irreversibility declaration at UNGA on September 24, framing denuclearization demands as 'unrealistic.'

Ryo Chol-ung · Vice Defence Minister, DPRK

Concluded Hanoi visit producing a DPRK-Vietnam closer defence ties pledge.

Bottom line: KCNA's dominant output combines an explicit 'collective punishment' threat against the ROK with a blanket rejection of nuclear test halt calls — both escalatory — while Kim Jong Un's last confirmed appearance was September 22. Watch for any Punggye-ri seismic activity and Kim's next public appearance.

• ROK GOVERNMENT

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Blue House confirms DMZ landmine probe ongoing with UNC; NK mine emplacement not ruled out

Senior presidential official

A senior presidential official traveling with President Lee in Mexico City told reporters the DMZ blast investigation is proceeding 'objectively, rapidly, and thoroughly' with UN Command, and confirmed the possibility of North Korean mine emplacement is 'open.' The official rejected claims of any cover-up, saying the site's high danger level required cautious approach.

[Primary](#) 뉴시스 ↗

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Blue House says Seoul received advance diplomatic notice — but vague — of Zelensky's POW remarks

Senior presidential official

A senior Blue House official said Korea was contacted through diplomatic channels that Zelensky might mention the North Korean POWs, but that 'the content was not clear' as to the exact form of disclosure. The official reaffirmed the government's consistent policy of handling the matter quietly for safety and legal reasons.

[Primary](#) 뉴시스 ↗

청와대 · BLUE HOUSE / PRESIDENT'S OFFICE

Blue House calls stable US-China relations 'basically positive' for Seoul; flags short trade-truce extension

Senior presidential official

A Blue House senior official said the management of US-China relations in a stable direction is 'basically positive' for Korea, but noted that the trade ceasefire extension to January 10 was short, suggesting the two powers have not set a long-term framework. The official said further analysis is needed to gauge the degree of benefit to Korea.

[Primary](#) 뉴시스 ↗

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY

DP lawmaker flags ROK agri-food tech gap — worst among major five nations vs. US

Agriculture, Forestry, Food, Marine and Fisheries Committee

Democratic Party National Assembly Agriculture Committee Chairman **Seo Sam-seok** released an analysis showing Korea's agricultural technology gap vs. the US stands at 3.1 years, behind EU (0.1 yr), Japan (2.3 yr), and China (3 yr). China and Japan have overtaken Korea in ICT-based aquaculture and fishery resource development technology.

• US-KOREA TRADE & INVESTMENT

Steel and aluminium stay at 50% and autos at 15%, both under Section 232. The Section 122 surcharge expired July 24, so there is no baseline reciprocal tariff. Section 301 is now the likely vehicle for any new

measure.

TARIFFS

EXPIRED

Section 122 surcharge lapsed Jul 24; Section 301 now primary tariff vehicle; sector 232 rates in force.

WATCH THIS DATE

next trigger: Section 301 determination — pending, no fixed date

SECTOR RATES		
Steel & Aluminum	SECTION 232	50%
Copper	SECTION 232	50%
Automobiles & Auto Parts	SECTION 232	15%
Timber / Lumber / Wood Derivatives	SECTION 232	15%
Semiconductors (advanced logic)	SECTION 232 (PROCLAMATION 11002)	25%
Pharmaceuticals	SECTION 232	up to 15%
Civil Aircraft & Parts	US-KOREA DEAL EXEMPTION	0%
Generic Pharma / Precursors / Rare Natural Resources	ALIGNED PARTNERS LIST	0%

FULL TRADE REFERENCE →

Investment ledger, pledge tracker and standing policy measures.

BUSINESS & ECONOMY

FINANCE · 매일경제

KRX after-hours market surpasses 4 trillion won in daily trading volume within one week of launch

Korea Exchange's new after-hours market (애프터마켓) crossed 4 trillion won in evening session trading volume in its first week, with after-hours volume growing at nearly 40% when the broader market grew only 5.6%, suggesting a significant shift in retail trading behavior toward extended-hours platforms.

Korea Exchange

MACRO · 뉴시스

Korea-Mexico bilateral investment protection agreement revised after 7-year negotiation

MOFA announced the revision of the Korea-Mexico investment protection treaty (original signed 2000, in force 2002), strengthening investor rights on capital repatriation and foreign exchange crisis scenarios, and adding anti-paper-company litigation safeguards — timed to Lee's state visit and the 2026-2030 Korea-Mexico joint action plan.

Reuters Morning Bid: US Treasuries catching Korean bond market volatility

Reuters markets analysis flags cross-contagion between Korean bond market volatility and US Treasury movements, a dynamic relevant to Seoul's external financing conditions as the BOK rate sits at 2.50% following a September cut.

• PUBLIC SENTIMENT

PRESIDENTIAL APPROVAL

37%

▼ 1 pts vs 2026-09-11

Gallup Korea · September 18, 2026

42% since Aug 25-27 ↓ 37% across 4 readings

RULING
Democratic**39%**OPPOSITION
People Power**25%**

INDEPENDENTS

26%**Gallup Korea Spotlight** September 18, 2026

Presidential Approval — New Low: President Lee Jae-myung's approval fell to a new low of 37% in the September 18 Gallup Korea weekly poll, down from 38% the prior week and below his previous low of 42% in August.

Discourse: Opposition PPP attacked the government for concealing the North Korean POW transfer from the public, calling it 'only mindful of Kim Jong-un'; the ruling DP defended secrecy as necessary for safety.

• UPCOMING

Oct
1**ROK Armed Forces Day (국군의 날)**

Also the anniversary of the ROK-US Mutual Defense Treaty, signed in Washington on 1 October 1953. Recent years have brought a parade through central Seoul and new systems shown publicly; alliance statements from both capitals usually land the same day.

Oct
3**National Foundation Day (개천절)**

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark, no Assembly business. Expect a thin domestic news flow and few primary-source releases.

Oct
9**Hangul Day (한글날)**

Public holiday: KRX closed, ministries dark. Falling within a week of 개천절, the two often bracket a slow stretch for government news.

Oct
10**Workers' Party founding day**

The party was founded on this date in 1945. Decennial anniversaries have brought large Kim Il Sung Square parades and new systems shown in public for the first time; watch pre-event imagery for assembly.

DPRK · 38 NORTH

Sister Before Daughter: Kim Yo Jong and the Normalization of Female Paektu Authority for Kim Ju Ae

38 North analysis by Jennifer Suh argues Kim Yo Jong's authority is being positioned ahead of Kim Ju Ae's in the Paektu bloodline succession narrative, normalizing female leadership within the regime's ideological framework before a formal succession becomes imminent.

DPRK · WAR ON THE ROCKS

North Korea's Irregular Warfare After Ukraine

War on the Rocks analysis examines how DPRK special operations forces' combat experience in Kursk may be transferred and operationalized on the Korean Peninsula, citing historical precedents including the 1968 Blue House raid and the 1996 submarine incursion.

DPRK · CNBC

Here's why South Korea wants more control over future regional wars

CNBC analysis examines ROK's push for greater wartime operational control (OPCON transfer) and Seoul's desire to reduce dependence on US command authority in future contingencies.

• ANALYSIS

OFFICIALS ON X

FM Cho Hyun @FMChoHyun

“I held a bilateral meeting with Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha in New York. Building upon the comprehensive assistance pledge for Ukraine announced by my government at the recent NATO summit, I conveyed Korea's intention to continue providing support for the Ukrainian people.”

Context: Meeting occurred at UNGA margins Sep 23; Russia's deputy FM separately warned Seoul the same period that military support for Ukraine would negatively affect Korea-Russia relations.

[View on X →](#)

FM Cho Hyun @FMChoHyun

“On September 23, I met with Iranian Foreign Minister Seyyed Abbas Araghchi in New York to discuss the recent Middle East situation and bilateral relations. On the occasion of this meeting, we signed a Korea-Iran prisoner transfer treaty.”

Context: The Korea-Iran prisoner transfer treaty signing at UNGA is the first such bilateral agreement between the two countries; the meeting is the fifth consecutive year Korea and Iran have held bilateral talks at UNGA.

[View on X →](#)

Direct posts by tracked official accounts, attributed as posted. Not independently verified beyond the post.



Jin Yong-seop

ROK JCS Chairman (General)

“The joint field investigation must be conducted with meticulous command-and-control, communications, rehearsal, and safety measures in place to ensure a thorough probe while protecting the safety of our soldiers.”

Analyst: Gen. Jin's Chuseok visit to the 25th Division underscored command-level urgency on the DMZ mine blast; the JCS simultaneously rebutted opposition and media claims that injured soldiers were evacuated by US military helicopters.

[Source →](#)



Lee Jae-myung
ROK President

"Mexico is an indispensable partner for South Korea. Our bilateral trade stands at approximately 28 trillion won and Korean corporate investment in Mexico exceeds 18 trillion won. The two countries are already underpinning each other's economies."

Analyst: Statement made at a Korea-Mexico business roundtable at Mexico's presidential palace during Lee's state visit; the summit produced the 2026-2030 Korea-Mexico joint action plan but a full FTA remains blocked by USMCA rules-of-origin negotiations.

Source →

COMMENTARY

THE DIPLOMAT

Constitutional Reform as the Lee Jae-myung Administration's Political Watershed

The analysis examines the historical debate over ROK's single five-year presidential term and the political dynamics surrounding Lee's repeated pledge not to seek re-election through constitutional revision. It situates the reform debate within Lee's current approval slide and the inter-party dynamics in the National Assembly.

• SATELLITE & LOCATION WATCH

3 of 11 sites at elevated or alert status

NK PRO / PLANET LABS · SEP 2026 — NORTH KOREA DUAL-COAST WARSHIP CONSTRUCTION

NK Pro satellite imagery shows new warship construction underway at Nampho and Chongjin shipyards simultaneously

Planet Labs imagery analyzed by NK Pro shows large hull sections being staged and assembled at the Nampho Shipyard on the west coast since early July and at the Chongjin Shipyard on the east coast, marking concurrent dual-coast naval construction. The Sinpo South Shipyard's Hero Kim Kun Ok SLBM submarine had already exited drydock in early 2025 but remains not fully operational. The simultaneous multi-site construction pace is assessed as consistent with Kim Jong Un's September 8 commissioning of the destroyer Kang Kon and his declared goal of nuclear-arming the navy.

→ Sinpo South Shipyard

NK Pro: North Korea starts building new warships on both coasts ↗

ELEVATED ▲

Yongbyon Nuclear Complex

IAEA confirmed North Korea built a new uranium enrichment facility at Yongbyon (Reuters/CNN, Sep 9-10, 2026), assessed capable of producing material for up to four additional warheads annually (조선일보). Russia dismissed the IAEA report at the Vienna session, citing lack of access. Apr 2026: Enrichment building expansion complete, new centrifuge hall operational. 5 MWe reactor and IRT-2000 both running. Thermal signatures consistent with increased plutonium/HEU production.

imagery as of 2026-09-10

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinpo South Shipyard

NK Pro satellite imagery (Sep 25) shows new warship construction begun at Chongjin Shipyard (east coast) and Nampho Shipyard (west coast) since early July — dual-coast concurrent construction. Hero Kim Kun Ok SLBM submarine exited drydock after 2+ years of fitting-out but still not operational as of May 2025. New submarine construction begun in separate bay.

imagery as of 2026-09-25

ACTIVITY ▲

Punggye-ri Nuclear Test Site

Nov 2025: ROK DIA assessed Tunnel No. 3 is test-ready and a nuclear test can be conducted at any time upon political decision. Site maintained at high readiness since mid-2024. Sep 9, 2016 fifth nuclear test 10-year anniversary fell three days ago; post-anniversary period historically carries elevated test risk. CNN/Yonhap reported Sep 18 that nearly 1,400 seismic events have been detected near the site since the 2017 test.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

ALERT ▲

Tumangang-Khasan (NK-Russia border)

Sep 8, 2026: The first road bridge over the Tumen River between North Korea and Russia was formally opened at a ceremony attended by Russian PM Mikhail Mishustin; the bridge is named after Soviet officer Yakov Novichenko. This constitutes a new permanent road link across the shared border, the first of its kind. NK News reporting confirms North Korea remains closed to private car travel via the bridge; crossings are limited to organized bus tours per the Association of Tour Operators of Russia (ATOR). NBC News analysis (Sep 15) frames the bridge alongside the near-complete Sinuiju-Dandong crossing as dual infrastructure bets by Pyongyang.

imagery as of 2026-09-15

ACTIVITY ▲

Sinuiju-Dandong (NK-China border)

Sep 21, 2026: ROK Embassy in Beijing confirmed the cargo carried by heavy trucks crossing the new Yalu River bridge on Sep 17 consisted of air-conditioning units (HVAC equipment) destined for the customs building, indicating construction is roughly 70-80% complete. Embassy source said the bridge could open approximately one month after building completion following a trial period, with the NK-China diplomatic anniversary (Oct 6) cited as a possible opening date. DPRK national insignia already installed on the North Korean customs building.

ACTIVITY ▲

Rason SEZ

Sep 21-22, 2026: NK Pro satellite imagery analysis shows a likely Russian cargo vessel docked at Rason for the first time since May 2026 — a roughly four-month gap after near-continuous activity in 2024-2025. Nov 2025: Chinese businesspeople re-entry to Rason SEZ expanded. Coal exports through Rason at highest levels in years throughout 2025. Arms export berth also active.

imagery as of 2026-09-22

ACTIVITY ▲

Vostochny/Dunai (Russian Far East)

Jan 2026: Arms shipments slowed due to ice — one Russian vessel (likely Angara or Lady R) visited Rason, docked Jan 14 at arms export berth. Cargo routed to Vostochny. Since Sep 2023: 64 voyages by 4 vessels (Angara, Maria, Maya-1, Lady R) delivered ~15,800 containers (~4.2-5.8M munitions) from Rajin to Vostochny/Dunai. Road bridge now open Sep 8, 2026, providing first permanent road route to supplement existing rail. NK News satellite imagery (Sep 18) shows ongoing upgrades to DPRK urban warfare training facilities consistent with troops rotating back from Russia.

imagery as of 2026-09-18

4 other monitored sites: no new imagery in the last 30 days · oldest report 2025-09.

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